

LIMA-NOX - Boxes

LightNovel.1

Iteration.1

Author, me lol

LIMA NOX - BOXES
by Amber Calliope

I can feel them, their gazes, their eyes must be meeting mine, it's scrutinous, and quite frankly I don't entirely find myself at peace with it. Nor with the hard plastic I find my rear seated on. There's a light coming from the left of me that they appear to be moving about, if I didn't know better I would say it was professor Earheart, given the shakiness of its placement. It's cold in this room. I feel like I'm being interrogated. It's a curious sensation to be working on something like this, and my gratitude is immense, but they simply don't understand the project. Something, nay a science like so, is not clean, it is bound to cause some complications in the propulsion labs, and naturally we're likely going to cause some blown fuse.

"Do you think the research you and your team is doing has been. Productive? Dyeter?"

It's the voice of a woman.. The twang at the end is Professor Earheart. The air feels stale here, and it's not helped by the 3 or 4 of them seated around me, there's a wooden floor beneath my feet. Oh, yes this is the secondary cabinet room. Yes, this was an interrogation.

"Yes, yes I would say so.. The project is going quite well."

"Yes?..."

"Yes."

"And you have. Nothing to declare?"

"Yes, madam I do but.. I do not think it would be appropriate given the circumstances of this meeting."

"That being?"

"You're not happy with the mess the ionic propulsion labs keep creating, and.. By extension I imagine you're not happy with me also.. Though I assure you the mess we create is perfectly within-"

"Scientific Study Diacrees—"

"Under section 9 yes—"

"Yes... Indeed..."

There is an.. Uncomfortable silence that has befallen the room, if not for the warmth somewhat seeping into my peripheries I would assume that this was a morgue for my execution.. Though Professor Earheart doesn't seem to be.. Particularly angry at me this time. It would be unfortunate if so I always struggle when the two of us are at odds within our work fields.. It tarnishes our outings when such things occur later...

The silence has not left, and I can hear the rattling of the atmospheric controls.. The ventilation shafts– It would make sense given how far down the hall this room was I suppose, this part of the building is quite old. Yes... the building– I do not appreciate this silence. I feel as though the daggers of their judgement pierce at me in this little seat.

"Dyeter, we aren't here to discuss the mess."

"Then-"

"We are discussing your lack of productivity because of the consistency of the messes your lab creates. You and your staff spend far too much time cleaning up the experiments rather than actually conducting them. It's begun to show a significant discrepancy in your lab's quotas."

"Apologies, you're correct yes but I believe that a good staff should be able to clean the messes they create, and the janitorial staff at the end of the day is able to clean whatever is left of our part of the-"

"You need one of your staff members to be cleaning your lab at all times. I admit, your work is impressive, and you more than anyone know that despite what some others in the prop labs.. Verbally excrete in regards to the sort of work you and your staff do for the project, I, Dr.Olen, Mace, and Feldmann, all have been more than willing to create accommodations for your research."

"Which I am very g-"

"Grateful for yes!.. Now if you would like to show your gratitude to us.. *And to me..* I expect at least one member of your staff to be cleaning things at all times rather than your entire staff pausing their experiments to clean up such things as.. Breaker failures."

That one stung a bit, I had a feeling that replacing the breakers on the Lab connections to the power core was a bad idea, though I didn't entirely regret the results we'd managed to accrue from overclocking the xenon jets.. It was messy yes, progress was messy, science was messy, the professors knew this, I knew this.. Still though I couldn't entirely neglect the fact that we had spent nearly 2 hours cleaning up the broken electrical parts.. Then another hour replacing them..

“Er- yes.”

“I can’t increase your funding I’m afraid. Which means one of your staff members will have to be given cleaning duty every day, you can cycle through it, or assign one of your members the responsibility per week.”

“I.. I’m afraid I’m not entirely sure how I’m supposed to do that Professor, all of us are working on important facets of the project.. And-”

“Dyeter. None of us have any particular scrutiny for how it gets done. Only that you don’t spend as much time on repairs. Am I understood? I know you have a personal belief in that the duties of such things should be shared by all but I’m afraid for the volume of work you’re doing the afternoon janitorial staff simply isn’t enough.”

“I understand.”

“Excellent, you’re dismissed. Mace, please mark this session adjourned and bring in Dylan of Lab 16 in please..”

The hasty shift in tone had been the metaphorical gavel hammering on the table that I needed but was hesitant to accept given its implications. The binders clapping, on the hardwood by Dr.Mace and the ruffling of papers as they prepared to bring in Dylan were all i needed to hear to know that this discussion was over, I stood from the chair and turned around before making my way to the door. Betwixt their less than approving gazes which I could feel behind me. The thoughts meandered in my brain over and over again.. Blaine.. I couldn’t assign Blaine to clean.. And in this case I couldn’t continue the group cleaning sessions.. I recall Dylan mentioning before that cleanup would become an issue yet.. Mmm.

The echoed steps of my shoes on the hardwood floor sound a higher pitch as I make my way onto the linoleum tiles.. The soft whistle of the old ceiling fans down this long hall, its walls the same consistency of paper. And the heavy breaths of the other lab heads sitting waiting for their turns in this vast hall.. It filled the air with a sour taste, rancid.. I suppose I got off lucky all things considered. Though, In my own way perhaps not.

I continued to step, familiar with these walls and the left turn about 12 paces ahead. I didn’t need Blaine to find my way around the Browder building. The chill of the air conditioning began to make way for the stale humidity of the street as I found my way to the foyer, ancient telephone rings, the stepping of other scientists and secretaries rang about.. The round marble and tiled floor. There was a sigh, even the engraved wooden walls and foyer staircases of this building couldn’t ease my worry. Nor did I need to pick my head up to be able to know Blaine was behind the bronze door on the staircase outside. Of which, the door opened without difficulty, but the slow turn to face her was easily...

Much, much harder to achieve. If the waves of the summer heat weren’t so palpable on my face I could probably feel the microwaves of worry coming off of her face.

"Well?..."

"They want us to stop spending as much time on the cleanups and repairs after our experiments..."

"So they're going to micromanage us like the higher labs? They don't even care about our research. Why would they bother getting on our case so much for this!?"

"It's.. not that simple"

"And? What are they gonna do, if not just give us an onsite foreman at that?"

"No, nothing like that...sigh"

Her curiosity was always appreciated in the lab, her ability to provide solutions, questions, at such quick speeds was exactly why I hired her as my assistant. Outside the lab however.

"They want a professor to watch us on staff at all times then is that it? I seriously don't understand why they would need to supervise us so thoroughly, especially given how many results we've managed to put out.."

Her immediate jumps to various conclusions could often be the last things I needed when concerned about something like so.. The issue, fundamentally, was not a big one. It was the lack of funding that would provide a complication...

"Worse, I'm afraid we need a janitor."

"So they expect one of us to clean? Isn't that what the evening staff is for?"

"They don't like that we keep having things like Thursday happening.. And unfortunately we don't have the funding for another hire.. Unfortunately, yes. One of us will have to clean."

"But that's ridiculous and you know it! I'm helping you, Mallorie is working on the gas mixtures and Fillion is busy with getting materials!"

"It's out of my control I'm afraid... We can probably cycle through each of us, one person each week spends time cleaning, our results might be a little uneven but they'll be faster I think-"

"No! Of course not! We just need someone else on hand to clean for us, just because one of us is cleaning at all times doesn't mean the tests are gonna get any faster, they'll just be slower, it's ridiculous!-"

Blaine led me down the concrete steps leading up the hall as we made our way down to the familiar radiating heat of the street, the scent of freshly cut grass changed the atmosphere.. It cheered me slightly but the change in tone in Blaine's voice sent a shock through my system.. Oh no.. she cut herself off which could only mean she was getting one of her unorthodox solutions.. Sarcastic or not I wasn't particularly eager to lend my ear to whatever it was she had in mind.

"Wait! Why not just get someone on service?"

As we stepped off onto the curb we walked between the cars parked by the sidewalk.. I waved my hand up to the left to hail a cab for us, I looked back at her unsure of what exactly she was speaking about. I racked my brain for a moment then just decided to be direct.

"I don't follow."

"Service, like, community service y'know? My cousin Ramona said her boss managed to do it once because apparently the judges prefer it if a local business or something takes their community service for them, they don't have to manage as many people for petty thefts."

"Blaine, I'm not enslaving someone to clean up our messes."

"They get paid for it! After they finish their service all the money they earned during that time is given back. And plus we're not paying for it, the board isn't paying for it, it would be the judiciary that would be paying for it, and we could get someone on just until we finish the first thruster tests. By then I'm sure we'd probably get more funding anyway. After they see that we were successful in our Gavate replica."

"It sounds... Unethical."

I stare off into the warmth ahead of me, the fields of blur coming down the street.. Why couldn't a cab just come sooner? I wasn't eager to discuss this with her, especially if it meant finding someone unfamiliar with the project who would be on staff.

"I just said they got paid for it didn't I? Besides, a lot of these people usually get stuck picking up trash or working sanitation, we'd be doing them a favour if nothing else. Better to have a propulsion lab's repertoire on your resume wouldn't it?"

Despite the difference in location, I felt the same silence befall between us as was in the board meeting prior. I stared off still.. Then I sigh.. Perhaps there was something else we could do, find a volunteer for the project, but most of the students had already applied to other locations by this point in the summer.. And we've had our applications for volunteers open since December..

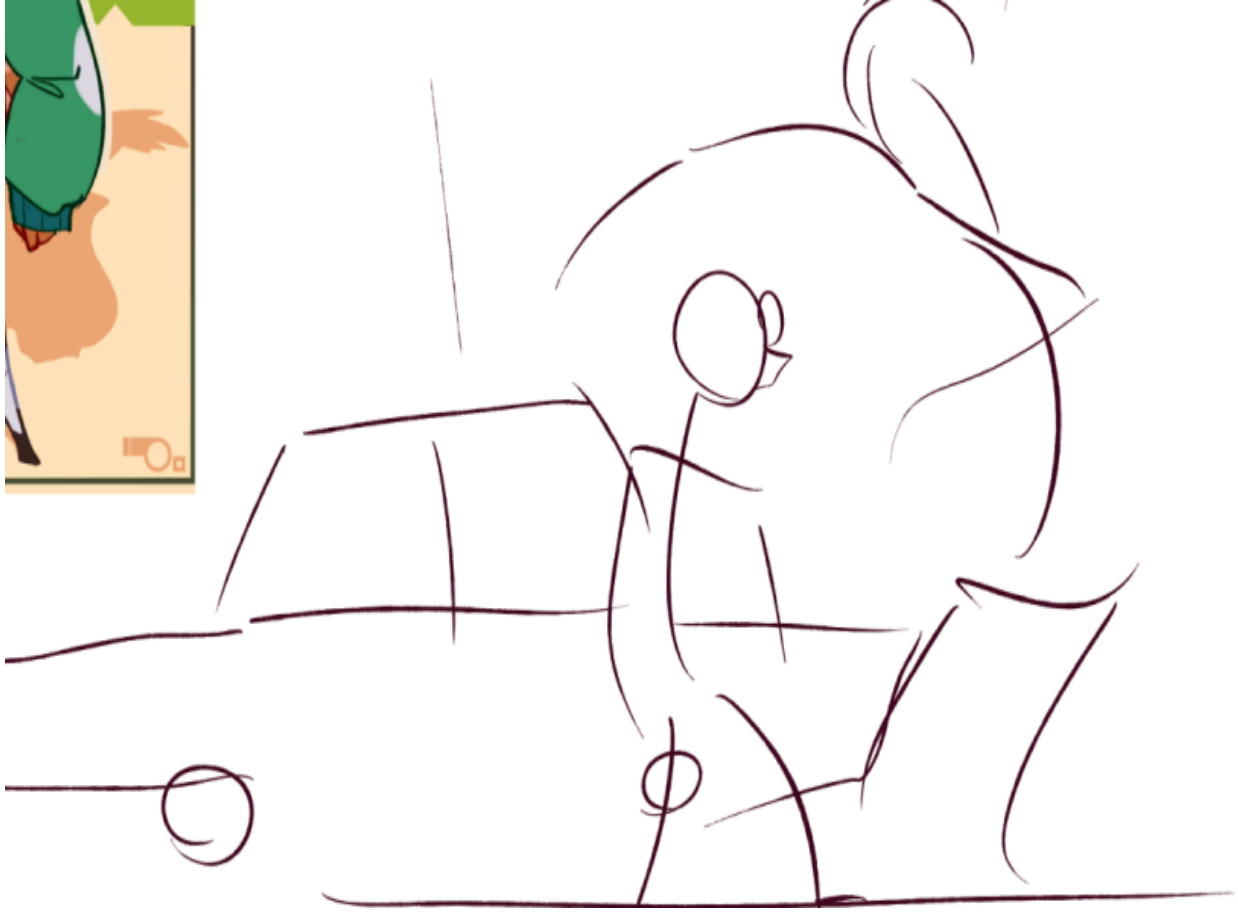
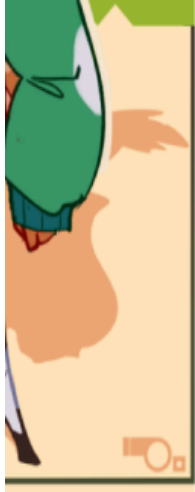
I desperately searched through my brain for another solution.. And sighed once more.. Deeply this time, exasperated. Had they wanted us to take a foreman it would have been an irritation, but, I wouldn't have to explain to them why standing in certain areas of the laboratory would be tantamount to stamping on 1000 petri dishes, the sheer volume of explanation to someone new to this project would be.. Difficult. I couldn't understand- or rather- I didn't want to admit I understood why they insisted we have someone constantly cleaning the messes. I can feel a deep breath of the fresh albeit warm air of the day.

I can feel my jaw clench as I prepare the words. I was... not particularly excited by the prospect of having someone on staff I was neither familiar with, nor could put my faith in the project for, especially someone who was going to be working for us specifically because they'd been proven guilty of some.. While petty, still innate criminal activity. Though I suppose I needed to be open in this case, regardless if we found a luddite or perhaps just someone misunderstood.. whoever it was we hired we still very much were in need of someone to clean the lab.

The familiar warm glow of the light bouncing off the blur coming down the avenue made it clear to me that there was a cab coming.. Likewise the honking of its horn.. I turn back to Blaine with a look of regret on my face.. Ah.. I can hear the smugness on her face.. Well.. this likely wasn't bound to be one of her best ideas, but it was at least, an idea. It was more than I could think of.

The cab pulled up to the curb.. The radio distracted me briefly, the host talking about a runaway driver or such.. Stolen object-technology... Shocking when I'd heard the story a few weeks ago but currently not a particularly big issue- I was more focused on Blaine, who was, still, giving me that look of hers... I hadn't come up with anything in the 12 second silent space I'd been standing there.. And sighed.

“Ok, fine. We'll do it, but at the first sign of complications we send them back to the judiciary. Where they come from is perhaps.. Of less consequence, the fact remains. We need a janitor.”

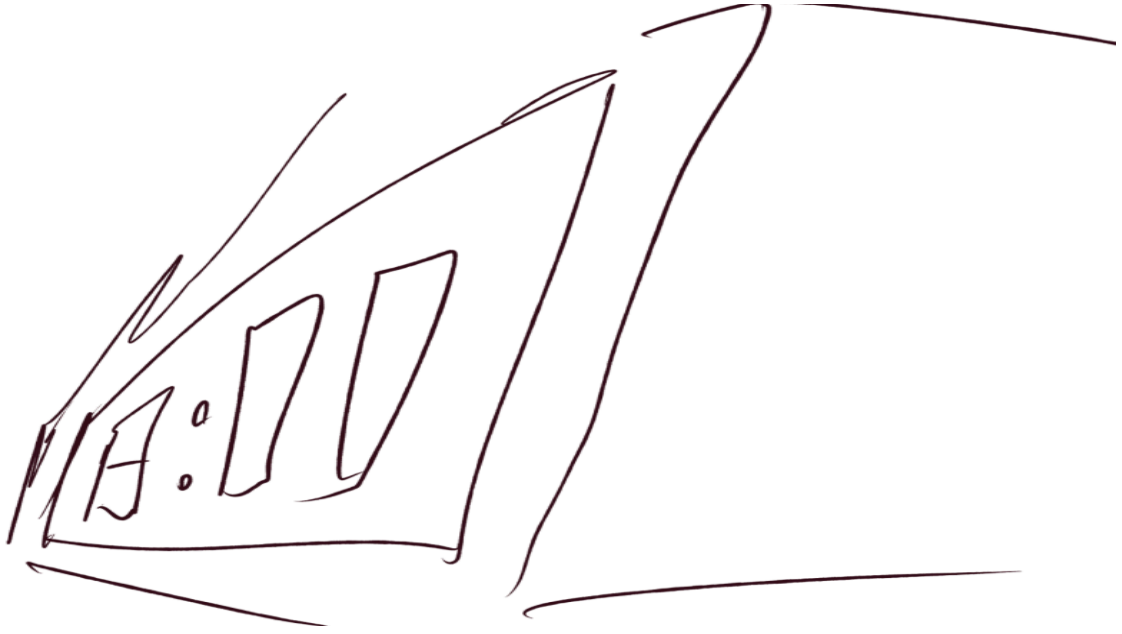


RRr rrRrR

Rrrriiiiiiiiiiii

nnnNGNGg

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RrrriiiiIINNngGGGGG

Mngmnh where, where's the off switch-rrGH. Turn offfff-Like please oh my gaaaaawwwwd.. Shuuuush.. Good.. ok that's the snooze button- now I can go back to sleep... Sleep... sleeeeeeeeep..... I can't sleep. Great, stupid plastic machine-ruined my day-ruined my sleep-in my nice bed. No... I can sleep, I just gotta try more.. Just gotta.. Get on this side of the pillow.. I don't have to go to work, I don't have to get breakfast or do anything.. Just wanna.. Sleep a bit more.

This is nice- This is great actually I loooooove this... Sleep- yeah I can go to sleep, I can totally go to sleep. Room.. sun on my room wall.

Not working.. Ok I'll just.. Like.. rot here for a little bit then... My feet are cold-my feet are cold why are my- Nevermind I'll just like-move here... Now my head is warm.. Hhhgh why did my window have to be right on the sunlight port areaaaaaaaaaa aaaaagh.. Fine. fine fine fine fine. I'll just shift over to the colder side of the pillow.. That'll do it..

Grhghghrrghgh

So-stupidly-bright-

"Gawd- just five minutes please ugh.."

Siiiiigh.. Ok I'll shift over here then.. It's a bit cooler on this side of the bed... Mnmnmnrgrhghg... Oh how fun-The bottom part of the blanket isn't covering my hoof.. Maybe like this.. Like this maybe?... rrrrghgh fine. I'll just curl up this'll work- this is good.. It's better than like.. Being freezing-This is nice.....

This is— just. Fine.

RRr rrRrR

RrrriiiiiNNNG

OK FINE I'M GETTING UP!!!



uuuuuuuuuuuugh dumb.. Alarm.. Ok fine.. Slippers.. Step step step.. Fun.. bathroom door.. Toothpaste.. Mm. Ok siiiigh what the hell did I have to do today? Work.. work at uhhh 10? 11? Sure, yeah like.. Whatever.. It's been about like 4 days since David was last in, maybe he's suffocated from kissing his boss' ass by now. Mmmmh.. Good.. Longer lunch break, and less time taping those stupid 10x2 boxes..

"Pththsheuu- ughhh this shit is absolutely gross. Toothpaste-tongue ew-"

Don't want that gross ass taste on my front teeth when I eat later.. Sigh, at least my shirts are clean.. Enough. Don't remember that little grease stain pip being on the side though that's really odd.. I better get that like.. Cleaned later or something.. Whatever, this one can just go on the pile. I'll clean it later. There.. This one is like, cleaner, mnnnugh it looks raggedy, too many folds.. Pile. There we go, this one's better.

Ok TV, let's see-Weather.. No rain.. No wind.. **Ugh**.. Hot. Great!! GREAT that's soooooooo nice great yep yep yep that's.. Yeah that's like exactly what I wanted, y'know what let's just turn on the heat to 100, it's not like we live in a big fish jar and those eggheads have like.. A thermometer on the wall to not make it miserable. Fun, thanks weather people, really doing your job, alright I'm out, is my bag around?.. On the table, yeah I think I like, left it there last night after uhhh, ah I don't remember.

"Shit!!- AchghK"

What kind of idiot leaves a bottle of vodka on the corner of the- Aaaghhhh paper towels right at least it's alcohol.. It's like basically cleaning itself right? Whatever it'll smell funky but at least it's dry now. And the bottle's back too at least... sleeping later is gonna suck though I should probably buy a new one. Whatev- door.. Lock.. close.. Ohhhh my gawd.. The sun.. the humidness.. Ugh today is going. To suck. Huff-

step stoc toc toc step-

Yeah... uhhhh 8 hour shift I think...

Same as usual.. No biggie.. No. Problem.

....

Siiiiigh

This blouse better not turn yellow after today.. The stupid weather technicians should lose their jobs at this point...Like.. I can't even begin to imagine how many people have to keep getting new shirts and stuff because they don't know how to just let the weather machines like.. Chill for a day or whatever.... This one is going to the pile too later I guess...

And I'm out of detergent toooo rrrrrrrghgrhghgrh... ok ok it's fine it's totally ok it's just fine everything is perfectly ok and I'm gonna go to work and I'm gonna do what I do every single day and it's gonna be fine and then I'll go to sleep on my nice.. Hot.. hot-cold.. Bed.. that doesn't cover my feet.. Or keep the sun out of my eyes.. Ugh.. being so observant is SUCH a burd-

Tall.. behind.. Guy.. sweaty shirt- ew- Oh Buffalo- man he's big too.. How the hell did I miss him? I was literally only looking at my collar for like 2 seconds?

"You freakin blind!? The lights red crazy lady.. Tryna push me into traffic or something!?"

"OH!!- I'm like so sorry sir I was um.. Not paying attention yeah-"

"Coulda walked into traffic or something- whatever.. It's fine just watch where you goin man."

"Yeah, like totally, right. Haha-"

Tool.

Ok, yeah time to start walking away now.. Don't make eye contact with him.. Just keep going down the street.. I mean.. I guess he was kinda right? I probably could have walked into traffic or something... Yeah.. bummer.. I could have like- got hit by a car or something.. Real tragic stuff.. Like that stupid Shakespeare stuff Mr Gordon would talk about in English class.. Whatever, probably time to start paying attention now.. Better than walking into some random dude's sweaty back.. eugh.

Y'know.. Like, Maybe the sun will kill me first though.. Sounds better than having to see David again anytime soon, ew, I could live without that image in my brain for the painful second time today.. Milt's is around the corner uuuugh, food, finally I think I wasted like a solid half my effort just imagining how awful today was gonna be.. I need something... literally anything. Anything that's not that Grasaus-

"Heyy Sorry... all we have is sausage brisket today, are you fine with that?"

"...Yegh!!... Hahaaaa I love the Grass brisket.. Yup-That's.. fine."

Just... Fine.

"Oh great I'll give you extra then!"

Why.

Do. I.

Open.

My mouuuuthhhhuuuuughhh...

There's people here.. Don't make a scene.. There's no need after all! Hahahaaaaaaa.

"Perfect! Ok that'll be three seventy-eight total, and uhh did you want something to drink with that."

"Coffee... Would be just fine, thanks."

That's ok!! I.. I kind of like sausage anyway!! My eyes not twitching.. I don't look insane.. I don't want to throttle someone right now or gag on the spot.. I just.. Want my coffee.. So I can get to work!! Right

"Hey lady, your order is ready! We got like a ridiculously big shipment today so I can like totally add even more act-"

"No thanks, this is perfect!- Thank you bye!!"

"Um-a-alright."

It's fine it's fine I'll just like.. Eat it.. And pretend it's some kind of like.. Actually edible matter, instead of this gag slop.. Eugh. WHY does it have to taste exactly like farts too- it even pollutes the eggs in it.. God, this is what I've been reduced to...

Better to just like.. Choke it down on the walk to work, 2 blocks left now I think.. It's not that much further, I can stomach this absolute GARBAGE, until then.. Then I get on the clock.. Maybe I can take my time a bit, I'm only gonna be like a few minutes late anyway mm- Guess I'll really admire the sights now.. Ok.. another group of buffy dudes.. All a bunch of meatheads.. Couple of others just like em.. Foul.. Pastry store.. Not today..

thoc stoc tac toc step-

Dude.. why did I have to end up in Teagan, everyone here is so like- braindead, the weather doesn't work, it's way hotter than Angelino like all the time, ads, ads, ads, NO I don't want a lawyer THANK YOU. Anyway.. Seems pretty standard today, plastic breakfast, tv screens showing the weather and the ads...Home, I could go home for a little bit- Brick wall buildings and like, parking lots.. No that would be-I'm not that desperate yet- sidewalk, mini parks, billboards on top of houses on top of convenience stores. Yeah no I'm not that desperate.

Oh jeez that door from the radio store is opening-

"OW!! Hey Watch where you're going you almost ran over my foot with your dolly dude!!"

"Oh- Sorry Miss I you're kind of walking in the-"

"YEAH I bet you're sor- You know what.. It's whatever."

Another moron.. This place is full of them.. I swear the plastic food and the 6 hours of tv must be like.. Rotting people's brains or something.. CAN'T YOU SEE ME MORON!?!- hhhhhhh- no it's ok I- I just need to calm down.. I

need to take a deep breath. It's not that big of a deal, totally an accident hahahahaaaaa... ugh. Oh, there's the brown roof. Oh joy work–today–for the next... I don't even remember how many hours. Keys–yeah I need those– there they are.

cRRSHhK-

Shift- right I'll just.. Get on shift then.. Just need to.. Get on shift there's my card.. Just.. like.. Slide it in.. and. It's not clicking.. Why isn't it click- go in! ggahhaHH!-

"Oh- Morning Ellie-"

I probably should have imagined he would be here by now.

"Hello, Captain ball peen."

"Unnecessary geez- I don't even work in that part of the shop anymore- no need to walk on that turf dude."

"Ellie is also absolutely a word that–like absolutely doesn't have to come out of your mouth like ever– just so you know."

"Ugh..Whatever. Sammy why doesn't the punch machine like–"

"Punch in?"

"Mmmhmmm."

"Uhhh it broke yeah, honestly I dunno but it shouldn't be too bad I mean like.. You could just tell David the hours you clocked in? He usually remembers to actually put the hours you did and stuff."

God. No. Under like– no circumstance do I want to have to see him today.

"Mhmm..."

"Yup- you figure that out I'll just be over by the sorter."

"Yeah–thanks Sammy you're a real gem y'know that?"

I swear to god if ONE more thing happens I think I'm actually going to strangle the first person I see.